Uzbekistan, Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan) who lost his throne to rivals and entered north India hoping to build his resources in order to recapture his original kingdom. Babur was never able to regain his Central Asian crown and his son Humayun and great-grandson Shah Jahan tried unsuccessfully to fulfil their ancestor's dream. Other Mughal emperors, like Akbar, Jahangir and Aurangzeb gave up the dream of recapturing Babur's principality and focused primarily on consolidating the empire in India. The subcontinent became ethnically and religiously more diverse under Mughal rule, laying the basis for a culturally pluralist India.

An affinity for the regions west and north-west of India, a frontier policy based on the concept of buffer regions and the use of Persian as the official language were not the only legacy of the Mughals affecting external relations. The British also inherited from the Mughals an institutional legacy of a personality-driven administration. Under the Mughals, while an imperial council or council of nobles (Diwan-i-Humayun) existed, the emperor was the decision maker.[31] The Mughals bequeathed lack of institutions and personalization of power to India's subsequent rulers. The British replaced Persian with English, tried to create a professional governing elite and laid some foundations of institutional governance. But they were unable to shake off the culture of personalized governance honed by seven centuries of sultanate, including Mughal rule. The ruler was more important than rules in Muslim-ruled India and the penchant for Indian officials to see themselves as the focus of the state has endured.

However, it can be argued that the modern Indian nation and India's contemporary sense of self were shaped primarily during the era of British colonial rule and not earlier. The British brought with them printing and modern means of communications, such as railways and the telegraph. They created schools, colleges and universities and a system of formal education that did not exist before on such scale. Indians in various regions could now travel to other parts of the subcontinent with greater ease, share ideas,